

FROM FLEDGLINGS TO WISE OWLS

Nurturing talent to new heights at Animal Logic

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Animal Logic

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ABSTRACT

For over 32 years Animal Logic has played a major role in the growth of the Animation and Visual Effects industry in Australia and globally. In this talk we will look at the breadth of initiatives, from hosting work experience student programs for high schools, through partnering with universities and hosting trainees. We explore how the company's values have been expressed through these, demonstrating how these have benefited the company and the greater community.

KEYWORDS

K-12, internships, training, education

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1 INTRODUCTION

1.1 Proposal

The purpose of this paper is to demonstrate that a company's commitment to learning opportunities over decades can have far-reaching beneficial impacts to the larger community.

1.2 “Great Work with Great People”

“Founded in 1991 and driven by a simple philosophy – **‘to create GREAT WORK with GREAT PEOPLE’**, Animal Logic is recognized as one of the world's leading independent creative studios, producing award-winning design, visual effects, and animation for over 30 years.”

In common with many of the pioneering companies in the field of computer graphics Animal Logic grew from earlier incarnations which focused on software solutions, into delivering advertisements, contributing visual effects to international productions, and finally developing and delivering fully animated movies. It has needed to be agile in many aspects of its approach to business, not least in developing talent.

To succeed, the company needed both a technically proficient and creative workforce. This has been achieved by a blend of both internal and external learning and development initiatives.

Because of its geographical remoteness, Animal Logic needed to find ways to build not just the company, but the available talent pool.

1.3 Setting the Scene

In 1991, Sydney was a very different place than the thriving hub of VFX and Animation that we see in 2023. While there was an Australian Film industry there were few ways to learn skills, no internet to speak of, and very few books available on the topic.

The world was yet to see the potential of computer graphics in film making:

- We were a year away from the release of Jurassic Park.
- 3 years away from Toy Story's debut.
- 7 years away from the first release of Maya.

2 THE RESPONSE

As there were multiple problems, we resolved them through a range of solutions.

2.1 Internal Training

2.1.1 Early days. Companies, particularly in emerging industries, face needs for new and specialized skills training.

By 2004 with the decision to adopt “Softimage” and “Massive” for the development of “Happy Feet”, Sofronis Efstathiou joined the company as our first training manager. (Traces of his approach can still be found in our approach to this day.)

His role encompassed the supervision, development, and implementation of three main functions.

- New Hire training – Artists new to the company were expected to be introduced to the show's software packages (whether commercial or proprietary) and have an appreciation of our production pipeline.
- Current Hire Training – Artists are continually exposed to new tools, updates, and new approaches to workflow. It was the training department's responsibility to facilitate this tuition.
- Training was not restricted to just tools and best practice, but also traditional film or performance techniques.

2.1.2 From Training to L & D. Nick Hore, Krista Jordan, and Drew Collins, (among others) continued the tradition of training and over the years, expanded upon it to become a more comprehensive “Learning and Development” department.

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Building on the work of predecessors we have faced the challenges of an evolving industry. We continue to adopt new technologies, and where possible create our own. All of this means that our teams are in constant need of training.

In addition, we have also sought to provide for employee opportunities for enrichment, growth, and improvement in a variety of soft and hard skills.

2.2 Outreach and Engagement

This section looks at the range of approaches which have been applied to nurture the development of future generations of employees, in schools, universities and in an early career.

2.2.1 Work Experience.



Figure 1: Work experience students being instructed in the use of Maya.

Animal Logic is committed to giving high school students the chance to experience a week working at the studio. This is run twice yearly in Sydney and gives young people who are considering a career in Animation a chance to work with award winning artists and see how a studio works.

We also host tours for students from schools, or youth organizations.

2.2.2 Bootcamps. When a particular skill is not being met by tertiary education, we have run internal bootcamps for graduates, many of whom go on to become employees.

2.2.3 Support for Ste“A”m. Whether in Vancouver or Sydney, we are committed advocates to the cause of improving the teaching of Science, Technology, Engineering, “**Art**” and Mathematics. Whenever possible we contribute to STEM events, often reminding them of the missing letter. (A)

We are strong supporters of events like the ACS Foundations “Big Day In” which promote these careers across NSW.

2.2.4 Tertiary Education Support. This can take the form of anything from curriculum advice, through to expert lectures, to presentations on portfolio preparation and how to find your first job.

2.3 A Fleet of Ships

2.3.1 Traineeships. Four talented trainees recently walked through our Sydney Studio doors as part of the Screen NSW Animation and VFX Trainee Placement Pilot Program.

The initiative was designed to give these young creatives experience working in a professional studio that will prepare them for the next steps in their careers.

2.3.2 Internships. The “Createability Internship Program” is a partnership between Create NSW, the Department of Family and Community Services (FACS) and Accessible Arts.

This scheme supports those working with disabilities in the arts, screen, and cultural sectors. It creates opportunities for young artists with a disability across the sector.

The program includes training followed by a paid internship for up to 160 hours at the studio.

2.3.3 Scholarship. UTS ALA Scholarships:

The Animal Logic Scholarship provides financial support to talented individuals from under-represented groups or those experiencing financial hardship in order to enable them to participate in



Figure 2: Animal Logic Artist and L & D Manager presenting to students at the Big Day In.



Figure 3: Trainees Lauren Bartie, Robbie Beresford, Nina Rokhatova, and Vella Tudor-Brown, with (then) COO Sharon Taylor.

postgraduate study in the animation, visual effects and visualization industries.

“Now more than ever, we need to provide opportunities for people from diverse backgrounds to build successful careers and share their stories,” said Animal Logic CEO, Zareh Nalbandian.

2.4 Animal Logic Academy

Established in 2017, the Academy is a custom-built digital production studio and teaching facility at the University of Technology Sydney (UTS). Mentored by industry experts, masters’ students are immersed in a full-time studio environment, working collaboratively on professional level projects using a combination of 3D animation and visual effects processes as well as pioneering the use of emerging visualisation technologies such as real-time animation.

Additionally, artist “Ambassadors” delivered talks to the company, outlining their practice.

2.5.2 Alab. ALab is a production ready scene made by Animal Logic for use by the wider community in demonstrations, training material, and in the testing of USD support across software and pipeline.

It has over 300 assets, complete with high-quality textures and two characters with looping animation in shot context, expanding on the static scenes released to date.

It is particularly valuable for education, training and students who wish to explore USD.

The ALab data set is the Animal Logic interpretation and implementation of real-world production and pipeline concepts. There are three downloads available at the ASWF DPCL website.

<https://dpel.aswf.io/alab/>



Figure 4: Students at the Animal Logic Artist Academy (UTS) learning in a simulated studio environment.

2.5 Novel initiatives.

2.5.1 Artists in Residence. The concept of this initiative was to provide NSW-based artists undertake a three-month residency with Animal Logic, supported by “Create NSW”.

Three artists were supported with a grant. As well as providing professional opportunities, Animal Logic hosted an exhibition of the artist’s output.

3 CONCLUSIONS:

3.1 The results

If you want to see the impact of Animal Logic on the local and global industry, a simple LinkedIn search can show the number of people who have at one point worked with us.



Figure 5: Ben Quilty, Aemmon Sheehan, Jason Phu, Técha Noble and Zareh Nalbandian.



Figure 6: A scene demonstrating the quality of assets from the ALab collection.

It's harder to calculate exactly how many people have been impacted by Learning and Development initiatives from the company, but I can say confidently that it has been significant. I frequently encounter people who have been through our work experience programs, heard talks from our incredible artists, or been part of the Animal Logic Academy.

3.2 Animal's Next Steps.

Without giving anything away, it is certain that the company will continue to innovate in both its support and delivery of educational opportunities.

3.3 The lessons to the larger community.

Committing to the development of, not just your studio, but the industry brings long term benefits. These are sometimes predictable, but often more subtle and pervasive, such as the shifting attitudes towards creative industries as a valid career choice.

Additionally, a single initiative may be impactful, but to create seriously impressive long-term benefits, a multi-pronged approach appears most effective.

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